

Tuscabibble's Guide to The Founding of the Moonsea Empire

A Note on Dates: For those not native to the Moonsea Empire, it may be helpful to know that history has come to be divided between two eras: BE (officially, “Before Empire”, but more informally and colloquially, “Before Edric”) and AZ (“After the Zhentarim”). The year 1 AZ was also the year 1375 DR (or Dalereckoning).

This may confuse some, because, although Edric Storm took Zhentil Keep in 1 AZ, it was technically not until 10 AZ that the Zhentarim were officially eradicated. But, as The First Stormlord was fond of saying, “Never let the facts get in the way of a great story!”

— Your Humble Servant, Rudolpho Tuscabibble

p.3, Tuscabibble's Guide to the Founding of the Moonsea Empire

A word about succession of the Storm Throne. Three laws govern who is or is not eligible to sit on the Storm Throne: the Blood Law, the Sword Law, and the Race Law.

Contemporaries say that Edric Storm gave little thought to the mechanics of succession because he used to say that he expected to outlive the end of the world. Scholars disagree whether he meant to live an unimaginably long time (for a human) or if, instead, he thought that the end of the world was likely to happen during his natural lifetime.

Unfortunately, that question (like so many others) was left unsettled when Edric I, Founder, High Ruler, and First Stormlord of the Moonsea Empire, disappeared while traveling somewhere near the border of Tesh and Cormanth provinces.

Before his disappearance, Laronen Moje, the Stormlord's most trusted friend and advisor, was able to convince him that the stability of the nascent empire required at least the barest minimum of a rule of succession. And so, in 48 AZ, Edric announced the Blood Law, a rule that required a man or woman must have royal blood (i.e., Edric's blood) in order to ascend to the throne. The Senate passed the law and every Stormlord since has been a direct descendant of Edric Storm I, either from his tempestuous marriage to Jessica Talianos, or from one of his many, many illegitimate offspring.

Please forgive your humble servant for taking liberties with the chronology of this narrative, as the Blood Law was not in fact the first rule of succession announced by Edric Storm. Some 46 years before the Blood Law was voted on by the Senate, Edric Storm I promoted Torbick Primus to be the first High Stormreaver. As a part of that decree, Edric announced that neither Torbick Primus, nor any future holder of that office could ever go on to sit on the throne: the so-called Sword Law.

The Stormlord's stated reasons for this restriction, as told directly to your humble servant in a Hilsfar brothel over several bottles of very expensive port, were two-fold. First, Edric felt strongly that no military leader should ever be tempted into behavior detrimental to the Empire in order to improve his chances to ascend to the throne.

Indeed, Edric was fond of telling the tale of a certain noble family formerly in charge of the Melvaunt city guard that had tried, unsuccessfully thanks to the efforts of a lowly pirate captain and his associates, to incite an orc invasion as cover for an attempt to dispose of the Council of Lords and take control of the City of Swords. (For more details, dear reader, please see the subchapters on the Bruel Militia, the Melvaunt Council of Lords, the orcs of Xul Jarak, and the Battle of the Scions).

Where did we leave off? Yes, of course, the second stated reason for the Sword Law: simple, military leaders have access to the most effective (and deadly!) means of coercion, which would inevitably be used to obtain the crown.

It was not until Edric's disappearance in 50 AZ that the so-called Race Law, came into effect. Although Edric Storm and Jessica Talianos had produced an heir - Torbick Storm, named after the first High Stromreaver, Torbick Primus - there were no fewer than two dozen claimants to the Storm Throne (all bastards and only a handful of them fully human) who came forward in the aftermath of Edric's disappearance.

Laronen Moje announced that Edric had privately told him that he intended to officially name his son, Torbick, as the official heir to the throne. Although Jessica Talianos refused to involve herself in the squabble over succession, multiple senators from powerful noble houses swore that Edric had confided similarly in them. In a session of the Senate open to the public, Laronen Moje cast a powerful scrying spell that showed the very conversation he had with Edric, naming Torbick. Given the amount of proof offered and the desire for a stable and peaceful succession, Torbick was affirmed as the heir apparent by the Senate during that same session (since Edric was only missing at that time, Torbick was not coronated for another two months).

Ah, yes, the Race Law. Oddly (or so it seemed to your humble servant at the time), Laronen's little magic show "revealed" something beyond just Edric's desire to name Torbick as his heir. During his conversation with Laronen, Edric expressed his concern that some of his less conventional mistresses might try to use his dalliances with them to seek power in the Moonsea Empire. Laronen suggested to him that perhaps only his legitimate heirs should be eligible, but Edric rejected that idea. Instead, he proposed that only his human descendants should be eligible.

And so, in that same session, the Senate of the Moonsea Empire passed the Race Law, forbidding "non-humans" from obtaining the crown. Ask yourselves, dear readers, just how much human blood makes a man a "man"? Half? Three quarters? Four fifths? Your humble servant does not presume to know, but the question persists, and likely shall do so long after this tome has been forgotten somewhere on a dusty shelf in the senatorial archives.

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The Recs and Xul Jarak

A few things the “recs”, short for “reclamation sites” which is a term for the Labor camps where the orcs of Thar have been enslaved since Edric Storm originally founded the Empire. First, Xul Jarak isn’t just the biggest of the recs, it is by far the most important. Most of the orcs at Xul Jarak came from other recs around the Gray Wastes (the swampy interior region of the province). There are no orcs at Xul Jarak who have been there more than 15 years. (2) There was a recent slave revolt at Xul Jarak (this is the thing Bruell scapegoated your father for) where hundreds of orcs had to be put down. The revolt was the talk of Melvaunt for a time, because it really has been centuries since the city had any need to fear the monstrous races of the Wastes. But the truth that only a select few in your family know is that it was not a revolt met with brutal force at all, but a mass suicide covered up by your father and made to look that way. You never learned why the orcs did what they did or how, but your father seemed certain it would be better if he was seen to have dealt firmly with some unruly creatures than to have somehow negligently endangered an important Moonsea industrial asset. (3) Although everyone refers to the “orcs” at the various recs, there are actually a few different humanoid races included among the prisoners. Mostly this is because the people of the Moonsea Empire never go to the recs - they don’t actually see the creatures in chains. Most of what they know about them is historical - the story of the Battle of Scions, and of Edric stopping a massive army of orcs intent on destroying Melvaunt. Part of it is a kind of lazy “they all look alike” racism that tends to conflate not just all goblinoids (goblins, hobgoblins, bugbears) with orcs, but also kobolds and gnolls. I feel like your family would know this and you can decide whether you are ever tempted to “akshually” anyone during conversations about the “orcs” of Xul Jarak. (4) Your family knows the “Secret of the Seventh Rec” but you’ve never heard the story. You know only that there was once a seventh rec and that it no longer exists and, for some reason, is not known about by Moonsea’s citizens or even mentioned by any of its historians.

Cormanthyr, Hilsfar, and The Gift

Before the rise of Edric Storm, the city of Hilsfar was an incredibly powerful and dangerous city. They called it the City of Trade, but the word had an insidious double meaning. Of course, Hilsfar is a warm water port on the southern shores of the Moonsea, and thus free from the annual icing that once hindered trade along the northern shores of the massive lake (for more on solving the icing problem, see my analysis, in Chapter 48, of the Thayan Alliance). So, Hilsfar was very much the largest hub of trade in the pre-empire days of the Moonsea region.

But there was another, more diabolical trade that gave the city its name - the slave trade. With the full backing and assistance of the Zhentarim, an evil sorcerer named Malthir the Mad had abolished the Council of Lords in Hilsfar and taken over the city. From 50 BE until 1AZ, Malthir grew the power and wealth of his despotic little kingdom on the backs of elven slaves.

Malthir handed down the two ironclad laws of Hilsfar: The Great Law of Trade and The Great Law of Humanity. The first of these held that any interference with legitimate trade (including the elven slave trade) was punishable by anything from confiscation of property to summary execution.

The Great Law of Humanity was, by far, the more problematic - humans were the only free people allowed inside the walls of the city. Humans could have their elven slaves, of course, but no other races were granted access to the city. Of course, the slavery was viewed as the very worst kind of insult by the elves of Cormanthyr, but even the dwarves were irate at being denied access to the city. So much so, that the craftsmen of Hammerfist Hold refused to trade with Hilsfar.

Each citizen was forced to carry a pass at all times, which verified his or her race as human and exempted the holder from the exorbitant exit and entry fees charged to visitors (generally 2 gp). All visitors were forced to sign a register, stating their business, affiliation and receive a visitor's pass (like a 30-day visa).

Hilsfar ran on elven slave labor. Tens of thousands of elves were enslaved and forced to fill every possible menial position, from hard labor to clerical and administrative. And, because Malthir had the protection of the mighty Zhentarim, there was nothing the elves of Cormanthyr could do.

Somehow, on his way to destroying the Zhentarim (See Chapters 10-16 on the fight to eradicate the Zhentarim), Edric killed the mighty despot and freed the slaves of Hilsfar. He restored the council of lords and elevated three families of elves to nobility and put them on the council to make sure the interests of the elves were represented in the city thereafter.

Freeing the elven slaves of Hilsfar was the act that solidified Edric's friendship with the Elven Lords of Cormanthyr, which in turn is how the Moonsea Empire came to receive its territorial dispensation to have its borders end one mile into the ancient forest of Cormanthor. Also, the

elves granted the Moonsea permission to an unprecedented level of access to timber from the forest. The Cormanthor timber — a renewable resource that replenishes at a magical rate, especially so the further into the forest one goes — is one of the keystones of the growth of the Moonsea Empire in its earliest days. So, this timber deal — known among the elves of Cormanthyr as ‘Storm’s Dispensation’ and called by the citizens of the Moonsea Empire merely ‘the Gift’ — is not just a matter of honor between the elves and Edric Storm, but also an important comparative advantage that Moonsea has over the other kingdoms of Faerun.”

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Glossary of Important People

Edric Storm

Laronen Moje

Lavinia Tuscabibble

Evan Norster

Danver Kane

Kara Kilaudra

Elaint Marsk

Calmon Laregon

Sindara Norster

Argens Bruel

The Symbol

Dundarion Greycastle

Torbick Primus

Torbick Secundus

Alton Greycastle

Jessica Talianos